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UNIT IV : WOODLAND WHISPERS

- SHAKUNTALAM – KALIDASA
- TRILLS AND THRILLS : BIRDWATCHING IN INDIA - SALIM ALI
- THE WILD SWANS AT COOLE - W.B. YEATS

SHAKUNTALAM – KALIDASA

COMPREHENSION : TEXTUAL PASSAGE

1. Read the excerpt from Birdwatching in India and answer the questions that follow

Dushyanta and the Deer

(Enter, in a chariot, pursuing a deer, King Dushyanta, bow

and arrow in hand and the charioteer.)

CHARIOTEER (looking at the king and the deer) : Your

Majesty, I see you hunt the spotted deer

With shafts to end his race.

KING: Charioteer, the deer has led us a long chase.

And even now

His neck in beauty bends

As backward looks he sends

At my pursuing car

That threatens death from far.

Fear shrinks to half the body small;

See how he fears the arrow's fall

The path he takes is strewed

With blades of grass half chewed

He leaps so often and so high,

He does not seem to run, but fly.

Pursue as I may, I can hardly keep him in sight.

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CHARIOTEER: Your Majesty, I have been holding the

horses back because the ground was rough. This gave

the deer a lead. Now we are on level ground, and you will

easily overtake him

1. According to the King, how does the deer's physical appearance change due to the fear of the pursuing chariot?

2. Why does the King mention that the path is "strewed with blades of grass half chewed"? What does this reveal about the deer's state of mind?

3. Why does the King describe the deer as "flying" rather than "running"?

4. What specific reason does the Charioteer give for why the deer managed to gain a lead on the King?

5. Based on the King's detailed description of the deer's "bending neck" and "beauty," what can you infer about Dushyanta's personality beyond being a hunter?

6. Which of the following best describes the King's perspective of the deer in this passage?

A) He views it as a slow and easy target.

B) He feels deep anger toward the animal for leading him on a long chase.

C) He displays a mix of predatory intent and poetic admiration for its grace.

D) He is frustrated by the Charioteer's inability to drive the horses.

2. Read the excerpt from Birdwatching in India and answer the questions that follow

The Warning

(A VOICE behind the scenes) : O King, this deer belongs to

the hermitage and must not be killed.

CHARIOTEER (listening): Your Majesty, here are two

hermits, who have come to save the deer just when your

arrow was about to fall.

KING (hastily) : Stop the chariot.

CHARIOTEER: Yes, Your Majesty. (He does so. Enter a

hermit, with his pupil.)

HERMIT (lifting his hand): O King, this deer belongs to

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the hermitage

Why should his tender form expire,

As blossoms perish in the fire?

How could that gentle life endure,

The deadly arrow sharp and sure?

Restore your arrow to the quiver;

To you were weapons lent

The broken hearted to deliver,

Not strike the innocent.

KING (bowing low): It is done. (He does so.)

HERMIT (joyfully): A deed worthy of you… a shining

example of kings.

KING (bowing low): I am thankful for your blessing.

Comprehension Questions

1. Who warns the King from behind the scenes, and what is the specific reason given for why the deer must not be killed?
2. The Hermit uses a vivid simile involving "blossoms" and "fire." Explain what this comparison reveals about the nature of the deer versus the King's arrow.
3. According to the Hermit's speech, what is the divine or true purpose of the weapons "lent" to a ruler?
4. How does King Dushyanta's physical reaction (his actions and gestures) demonstrate his respect for the Hermit's authority?
5. What is the Hermit's final opinion of the King after he restores his arrow to the quiver?

6. Why does the Hermit describe the King's obedience as a "shining example"?

- A) Because the King showed he is a better hunter than the hermits.
- B) Because the King chose to exercise mercy and follow sacred laws over his own desire.
- C) Because the King's armor was literally shining in the sun.
- D) Because the King gave his weapons to the hermitage as a gift.

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ANSWERS

SET 1

1. The deer's body appears to shrink to half its body small. This describes how the deer tenses its muscles and draws itself together in extreme terror, making its frame look smaller as it prepares for high-speed leaps.

2. The "half-chewed" grass indicates that the deer was caught by surprise while grazing. It reveals a state of intense panic and urgency; the deer was so startled that it dropped its food mid-bite to flee for its life.

3.The King describes it as "flying" because the deer is leaping so often and so high that it spends more time in the air than on the ground. Its movement is characterized by grace and suspension rather than just the heavy steps of running.

4. The Charioteer explains that the rough ground forced him to hold the horses back to maintain control. This decrease in the chariot's speed allowed the deer to gain a significant distance.

5. The description reveals that Dushyanta is a refined and poetic individual. Even while acting as a predator, he is deeply moved by the aesthetic beauty of nature. He possesses a sensitive eye that appreciates grace and elegance, suggesting he is more than just a cold-hearted hunter.

6.C (He displays a mix of predatory intent and poetic admiration for its grace.)

SET 2

1. A voice from behind the scenes (the Hermit) warns the King. The reason is that the deer belongs to the hermitage (a sacred sanctuary) and is therefore protected.

2. He compares the deer to blossoms perishing in a fire. This emphasizes that the deer is delicate and innocent, while the arrow is a destructive force that the "gentle life" cannot possibly withstand.

3. Weapons are meant to deliver (save) the broken-hearted and protect the innocent, rather than to cause harm to helpless creatures.

4. The King reacts hastily to stop the chariot and bows low. This shows his humility and his recognition that spiritual/moral laws are higher than his own royal whims.

5. The Hermit is joyful and praises the King, calling his restraint a deed worthy of a great ruler and a "shining example" for all kings to follow.

6. B) Because the King chose to exercise mercy and follow sacred laws over his own desire.

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DISCOURSES

CHARACTER SKETCH

King Dushyanta

"King Dushyanta's character is a blend of a fierce warrior and a humble protector." Prepare a **charcter sketch of King Dushyanta** with reference to his actions in the forest and his response to the Hermit's intervention.

Based on the opening scenes of the play, King Dushyanta is portrayed as a multifaceted character who embodies the qualities of a heroic leader, a skilled hunter, and a respectful follower of *Dharma* (righteous duty). Initially, he is seen as a man of action and vigor, pursuing a deer with intense focus and expert skill. His poetic descriptions of the fleeing animal reveal a refined, aesthetic side; he is not merely a predator but a connoisseur of beauty, capable of admiring the "bending neck" and "graceful leaps" of his prey even as he prepares to strike.

However, the most defining trait of his character in this part of the play is his humility and sense of duty. Despite holding supreme power, he immediately halts his pursuit at the command of a simple hermit. By "bowing low" and restoring his arrow to the quiver, Dushyanta demonstrates that his ego is subordinate to sacred law. He transitions seamlessly from a fierce warrior to a "shining example of kings," proving that his true strength lies in his self-restraint and his commitment to protecting the innocent rather than merely asserting his dominance over nature.

REVIEW

"The opening of the play moves from a scene of 'aggression' to a scene of 'grace.' Prepare a **review** highlighting how the playwright achieves this transition through the King's actions."

Review: The Hunt and the Hermitage (Act I)

The play opens with high-octane energy. The vivid description of the deer's flight creates a sense of breathless speed, instantly pulling the audience into the King's world of the hunt. The transition from the dusty, adrenaline-filled chase to the quiet, disciplined boundaries of the hermitage is masterfully handled, shifting the tone from aggression to grace.

King Dushyanta is introduced not as a one-dimensional ruler, but as a man of high sensitivity. His ability to describe the deer's "half-chewed grass" and "bending neck" shows a deep connection to nature, even while he pursues it. This makes his later submission to the Hermit feel natural rather than forced. The Hermit, though physically powerless compared to the King, wields a moral authority that defines the play's ethical compass.

The core of this section is the lesson on the true purpose of power. The Hermit's plea—that weapons are meant to protect the broken-hearted, not strike the innocent—serves as a powerful reminder of *Dharma* (righteousness). The King's decision to put his arrow back in the quiver is the first major "victory" of the play, though it is a victory of character rather than a victory of the hunt.

This opening is a brilliant study in restraint. It establishes Dushyanta as a hero worthy of our respect, not because of his skill with a bow, but because of his willingness to listen to his conscience. It sets a beautiful stage for the romantic and spiritual journey that follows.

An introduction to Shākuntalam

As part of a student exchange programme, you engage in a session on theatre with a group of Class 10 learners from your neighbouring state. Prepare an introduction to Shākuntalam for their benefit. You may highlight the theatrical techniques, the setting, characters and sequence of events.

Introduction to Shākuntalam: A Journey from Court to Forest

Good morning, everyone! Today, we are stepping back nearly 1,500 years into the world of Kalidasa, often called the "Shakespeare of India." His most famous play, *Abhijnanashakuntalam*, is not just a story; it is a sensory experience of ancient India.

1. The Setting: Two Different Worlds

The play moves between two contrasting locations:

- The Royal Court: Representing power, structure, and social duty.
- The Hermitage (Ashram): A sacred forest sanctuary where humans, animals, and plants live in harmony. This is a place of peace where even a King must set aside his weapons.

2. The Main Characters

- King Dushyanta: A noble and powerful ruler, but also a man of deep poetic feeling and humility.
- Shakuntala: The daughter of a sage and a celestial nymph. She represents the purity of nature itself.
- The Forest Dwellers: Including the hermits and Shakuntala's friends, who act as the moral conscience of the story.

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3. The Sequence of Events (The Opening)

The play begins with a high-speed chase. King Dushyanta enters in a chariot, pursuing a deer. Just as he is about to shoot, he is stopped by a voice from a hermitage. This moment is the "inciting incident"—it changes the King from a hunter into a guest of the forest, leading him to meet Shakuntala.

4. Unique Theatrical Techniques

Sanskrit theatre uses specific techniques that you might find different from modern movies:

- Nandimukha (The Prologue): The play begins with a prayer to Lord Shiva to bless the performance.
- The Sutradhara: A "Stage Manager" or narrator who introduces the play to the audience.
- Rasa (Emotion): The goal of the play is to make the audience feel a specific emotion. In this act, we move from Vira Rasa (Heroic/Energy) during the hunt to Shanta Rasa (Peace) at the hermitage.